BEING CORNERED

- The 'common man' CM was blamed for show of opulence—Rs 45 crore was allegedly spent on the renovation of his official residence
- In March, deputy CM Manish Sisodia, the closest confidant of Kejriwal, was arrested by the ED for his alleged involvement in the liquor scandal. Kejriwal has not responded to two ED summonses
- The Centre overturned an SC ruling—which gave the AAP government legislative power over bureaucrats, excluding the departments of public order, police and land—by passing a law
- There has been no end to Kejriwal's perennial conflict with the office of LG, irrespective of the individual occupying the chair



DELHI CHIEF MINISTER ARVIND KEJRIWAL shot into national prominence in 2011 with his anti-corruption campaign. Championing a model of transparent governance, he rose from a political novice to an unprecedented success story, capturing power for two consecutive terms in the national capital. However, the narrative took an ironic turn over a decade later when Kejriwal became entangled in corruption charges related to the controversial rollout of a liquor policy. The once-common man CM, known for his bush shirt and muffler, also faced accusations of opulence, with claims of Rs 45 crore spent on renovating his official residence.

Despite the euphoria following the electoral triumph in Punjab last year, 2023 brought a series of setbacks for Kejriwal's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). In March, his closest confidant and deputy CM Manish Sisodia was arrested by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in connection with the liquor scandal. He became the second minister, after Satyendar Jain, jailed for alleged financial malpractices.

Expectedly, Kejriwal denounced the arrests as a political vendetta orchestrated by the BJP-led Central government. He remained defiant, ignoring two summonses from the ED. His supporters have begun crafting a narrative that Kejriwal will govern from jail—not surprising amid charges of his alleged remote control over the Punjab government led by CM Bhagwant Singh Mann.

The tussle with the Central government extended to the appointment and transfer of civil servants in Delhi. In May, the Supreme Court ruled in favour of the AAP government, affirming its legislative power over bureaucrats, excluding the departments of public order, police and land. However, the Union government swiftly countered it by passing a law granting itself authority over appointments and transfers. Chief secretary Naresh Kumar became a focal point, painted by Kejriwal's government as a Union government stooge. In November, the CM wrote to Lieutenant Governor V.K. Saxena seeking Kumar's removal for allegedly enhancing an "exorbitant compensation award" for a parcel of land. But hours before Kumar was to superannuate, the Centre granted him a six-month extension—later approved by the SC.

Kejriwal's perennial conflict with the LG's office continues, marked by terminations of 400 specialists in July and a recommended CBI inquiry into alleged drug procurement irregularities in state government hospitals in November.

Nevertheless, the only bright spot was the AAP's recognition as a national party in April—the sixth one to achieve such status. Yet, its abysmal performance in this year's assembly polls has prompted Kejriwal to reassess his strategy to go solo as a national player.

The AAP joined the anti-BJP Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). He also managed to get the Congress's parliamentary support against the law stripping the Delhi government's bureaucratic powers. But the truce was short-lived, with no seat-sharing in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh. Meanwhile, the AAP chief seems to have not forgotten Rahul Gandhi's snub—he has not got an appointment with the Gandhi scion since he first sought it in May. This month, in the fourth meeting of INDIA, Kejriwal, along with his West Bengal counterpart Mamata Banerjee, proposed Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge as the alliance's PM candidate. More than a climbdown from his own prime ministerial aspiration, it was aimed at negating the space for Rahul—viewed by several INDIA allies as the weakest link against Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the Lok Sabha polls. ■

Kejriwal is the second CM heading a national party after Meghalaya's Conrad Sangma, chief of the National People's Party